Send Your Name to Saturn's Largest Moon

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NASA is getting ready to send a robot helicopter to a faraway moon and your name can ride along. The spacecraft is called Dragonfly, an eight-bladed **rotorcraft** headed for Titan, the largest of Saturn's 292 known moons. Its launch is planned for no earlier than July 2028, and after more than six years of travel, it would reach Titan in 2034.

As part of its Journey to Titan campaign, NASA has opened an online registry for names to be placed on a microchip aboard the spacecraft. Signers will get a digital boarding pass. The names will not help run the mission, but Nicky Fox, NASA's Science Mission Directorate associate administrator, said the agency is excited to bring humanity along and invites everyone to join the small but mighty **rotorcraft**'s journey.

Titan is a longtime dream destination in the search for life beyond Earth. It has dusty dunes overlooking lakes and rivers of **methane**, and a surface near minus 290 degrees Fahrenheit, **inhospitable** to life as we know it. Yet a giant ocean hides beneath its icy shell. **Astrobiologists** widely agree those waters probably contain enough complex compounds to support a **prebiotic** environment, and laboratory simulations have indicated Titan's atmosphere can form some building blocks for DNA and RNA. If true, microbial life may exist in the moon's hidden waters but no one can confirm it without going there.

That is Dragonfly's job. After landing, it will hop to different places during a planned three-year mission, traveling 70 miles and visiting 20 to 30 areas while searching for signs of **habitability**. Dragonfly is under construction at the Johns Hopkins Applied Physics Laboratory in Laurel, Maryland, as the fourth mission in NASA's New Frontiers Program. Sign-ups close at 11:59 p.m. EST on January 15, 2027.

Word Treasure

rotorcraft -- An aircraft that flies using spinning blades instead of wings.
methane -- A gas that can form lakes and rivers on Titan.
inhospitable -- A place too harsh for living things to survive in.
Astrobiologists -- Scientists who study whether life might exist beyond Earth.
prebiotic -- Relating to the chemical steps that could come before life begins.
habitability -- How suitable a place is for living things to survive.

Background you need

Titan is a large moon that orbits the planet Saturn, and it is covered by a thick atmosphere that hides its surface from view.

Scientists are interested in Titan because it has lakes and rivers of liquid methane and a hidden ocean of water beneath its icy outer shell, which could hold the ingredients needed for life to begin.

Dragonfly is a rotorcraft built to fly through Titan's thick air and hop from place to place, sampling the ground and air to look for signs that the moon could support life.

Sending a flying explorer lets scientists study many different areas of Titan instead of staying in one spot, which is why the mission was planned as a long journey to a distant world.

Break it down

LEAD: NASA is sending the rotorcraft Dragonfly to Titan, and people can send their names along on a microchip.

KEY EVENT: NASA opened an online registry for names as part of its Journey to Titan campaign.

+- WHO: NASA, and Nicky Fox, NASA's Science Mission Directorate associate administrator

+- WHAT: Names will be placed on a microchip aboard Dragonfly, and signers will get a digital boarding pass

+- WHEN: Sign-ups close at 11:59 p.m. EST on January 15, 2027; launch is planned for no earlier than July 2028, with arrival in 2034

EVIDENCE: Titan has dusty dunes overlooking lakes and rivers of methane, a surface near minus 290 degrees Fahrenheit, and a giant ocean beneath its icy shell; astrobiologists widely agree its waters probably contain enough complex compounds to support a prebiotic environment, and laboratory simulations have indicated its atmosphere can form some building blocks for DNA and RNA

MISSION: After landing, Dragonfly will hop to different places during a planned three-year mission, traveling 70 miles and visiting 20 to 30 areas while searching for signs of habitability

OPEN QUESTION: Whether microbial life exists in Titan's hidden waters, which no one can confirm without going there

Why it matters

Exploring Titan's hidden ocean could help answer whether life can exist beyond Earth, and the name registry lets the public share in a mission that tests that big question firsthand.

Test what you remember

1. What is Dragonfly?

- (A) A satellite that will orbit Saturn
- (B) A telescope that will watch Titan from Earth
- (C) An eight-bladed rotorcraft headed for Titan
- (D) A crewed spacecraft that will carry people to Titan

2. When is Dragonfly's launch planned?

- (A) In 2034
- (B) No earlier than July 2028
- (C) On January 15, 2027
- (D) After its three-year mission ends

3. What happens to a name signed up through the Journey to Titan campaign?

- (A) It will be painted on the outside of the spacecraft
- (B) It will be placed on a microchip aboard Dragonfly, and the signer will get a digital boarding pass
- (C) It will be sent to Titan by radio after landing
- (D) It will help run the mission's navigation system

4. Why do scientists find Titan promising in the search for life beyond Earth, despite its cold surface?

- (A) It is the closest moon to Earth
- (B) Its surface is warm enough for life as we know it
- (C) A giant ocean hides beneath its icy shell, and its waters probably contain enough complex compounds to support a prebiotic environment
- (D) It has no atmosphere

5. During its planned mission after landing, what will Dragonfly do?

- (A) Return samples to Earth in 2034
- (B) Stay in one place for three years
- (C) Hop to different places, traveling 70 miles and visiting 20 to 30 areas while searching for signs of habitability
- (D) Orbit Titan for six years

6. Where is Dragonfly under construction?

- (A) At a launch site in Florida
- (B) On Titan
- (C) At NASA headquarters in Washington, D.C.
- (D) At the Johns Hopkins Applied Physics Laboratory in Laurel, Maryland

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: B 3: B 4: C 5: C 6: D

Questions to think about

1. NASA, through Nicky Fox: The agency is excited to bring humanity along and invites everyone to join the small but mighty rotorcraft's journey.

2. Astrobiologists: They widely agree Titan's hidden waters probably contain enough complex compounds to support a prebiotic environment.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):